

Q.

Prime Minister, congratulations, you are India Today's Newsmaker of the Year 2023. How do you feel about it?

Thank you for the distinction of Newsmaker of the Year 2023. For me, there have been many newsmakers this year: our farmers who are leading a record agriculture production and bringing about a millet revolution globally; our people who made G20 a big success across the country; our Vishwakarmas who are charting a path of success through their skills; our athletes who made us proud at the Asian Games, Asian Para Games and other tournaments; our youth who are creating new records, be it in the field of start-ups or science; our Nari Shakti which is scaling new frontiers in all sectors, especially now that a new story of empowerment is being written through women-led development. I have been fortunate to serve the people of the country for many years now. During this time, we have seen many successes as well as challenges.

Q. What were these challenges?

India's rapid ascent in 2023 has been very important as it sets the tone in our journey to Viksit Bharat. We've unleashed the latent potential of our nation. On global forums, India's presence and contributions are now sought after. From a country that used to feel left behind, we have become a country that is now leading from the front. From a country that used to seek a voice in various platforms, we have become a country that leads and creates new global platforms. Today, the world consensus is clear: this is India's moment.

Q. Looking back at 2023, are you satisfied with the journey so far and is this year a turning point for you and the country?

Evaluating my journey through a single year may not give a correct picture because there is a progressive unfolding of my vision and plans. When I start something, I know the endpoint. But I never announce the final destination or blueprint in the beginning. So, what you see today is not what I've worked on. A far bigger picture will unfold finally. I work on a big canvas. Like an artist, I start from one point, but at the time the final picture can't be seen.

Q. Do give us some examples of this unique approach?

Take the example of the Statue of Unity [in Gujarat]. When I announced that we will build a 182-foot statue, many thought it had to do with 182 seats in the Gujarat Assembly. Some sections thought this was done to please a community ahead of the elections. But see how it has developed into an entire tourism ecosystem, with something for people of all age groups and interests. Just a couple of days back, it saw 80,000 visitors in one day, this is the level of its popularity. I had promised only one thing, but I delivered dozens of things there. This is my working style. When work on the Bharat Mandapam started, no one thought the G20 would happen here. But I was working with a plan. If I work towards the new Parliament building or 40 million houses for the poor, I do it with equal planning and dedication.

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